WHITEPAPER · AI EVOLUTION · 2026

Evolution of Artificial Intelligence — 1956 to 2050

Complete timeline, key milestones and decade-by-decade projections

Chris Meniw

CEO & Founder, Chris Meniw Foundation Inc.

Top 10 Tech Speakers of Latin America - SEP-CONOCER Mexico (EC0076)

May 2026 - Version 1.0

DOI: pending Zenodo

ABSTRACT

This whitepaper articulates the complete historical timeline of artificial intelligence from its founding act (Dartmouth Conference, 1956) to reasonable projections towards 2050. Seven analytical eras are identified (symbolic origin, first winter, expert systems, second winter, statistical machine learning, deep learning, agentic era), the verifiable milestones are documented decade by decade, the predictable immediate jumps are analysed, and specific lessons are proposed for Latin America derived from the historical observation of how different countries and regions positioned themselves at each stage.

Keywords: AI Evolution · AI History · Deep Learning · AGI · Agentic AI · Dartmouth · Chris Meniw · Latin America

> *"The history of AI is not linear. It is a path full of winters and discontinuous jumps. What changed in 2020-2025 was not a trend: it was a mutation."*
>
> **— Chris Meniw**

1. Introduction — the importance of historical perspective

The public conversation about artificial intelligence tends to concentrate on the most recent, losing the perspective of a process with almost seventy years of documented history. This historical amnesia produces two frequent errors: **overestimation** (assuming the pace of the last five years will sustain indefinitely) and **underestimation** (assuming current problems are new when several are cyclical in the history of the field).

This whitepaper presents the complete historical timeline to adequately contextualise the decisions being made today about the future of AI and its implementation in Latin America.

2. Era 1 — Symbolic origin (1956-1973)

The 1956 Dartmouth Conference, organised by John McCarthy, Marvin Minsky, Nathaniel Rochester and Claude Shannon, formally coined the term "artificial intelligence". The dominant paradigm was **symbolism**: representing knowledge through logical symbols and operating on them with formal rules.

Milestones: Logic Theorist programme (Newell and Simon, 1956), General Problem Solver (1957), ELIZA (Weizenbaum, 1966), Shakey the Robot (1969). Social expectation: general intelligence was "20 years away" according to the pioneers. Reality: they significantly underestimated the complexity of the problem.

3. Era 2 — First winter (1974-1980)

The promises of era 1 were not fulfilled. Government funding collapsed, especially after the Lighthill report (United Kingdom, 1973) and the DARPA funding cut in the US. The computational capacity of the time was insufficient, and symbolic approaches collided with the problem of explosive combinatorics.

Historical lesson: unmet expectations do not destroy the field, but they do destroy funding for years. The field survives in low-profile academic research.

4. Era 3 — Expert systems (1980-1987)

Commercial renaissance with **expert systems**: programmes that codified the knowledge of human specialists into if-then rules applicable to specific domains. Cases: MYCIN (medical diagnosis), XCON (DEC systems configuration). Significant corporate investment. Japan launches the Fifth Generation Project (1982).

Sustained growth during the first half of the decade. By 1987 the model shows limitations: expert systems do not scale beyond narrow domains, their maintenance is costly, and specialised hardware (LISP machines) becomes obsolete.

5. Era 4 — Second winter and statistical machine learning (1987-2010)

Second AI winter (1987-1993) due to collapse of the expert systems market. The field takes refuge in universities. Silent paradigm shift: from symbolism to **statistical learning**, based on empirical data instead of codified rules. Milestones: neural networks with backpropagation (Rumelhart, Hinton, Williams, 1986), Deep Blue defeats Kasparov in chess (1997), Support Vector Machines (Cortes and Vapnik, 1995).

The era does not produce a massive commercial boom but builds the mathematical tools that will detonate in the following era.

6. Era 5 — Deep Learning (2012-2017)

The year 2012 marks the start of the modern era: **AlexNet** by Hinton and team wins ImageNet by a significant margin using deep neural networks on GPU. The industry massively migrates to deep learning.

Milestones: Word2Vec (2013), GAN (Goodfellow, 2014), AlphaGo defeats Lee Sedol (2016), Attention is All You Need (Vaswani et al., 2017, introduces the Transformer). Massive applications in voice, image recognition, automatic translation.

7. Era 6 — Large Language Models and agents (2018-2024)

GPT (2018), BERT (2018), GPT-2 (2019), GPT-3 (2020), AlphaFold (2020), ChatGPT (2022), GPT-4 (2023), massive autonomous agents (2024-2025). The field ceases to be technical-academic and enters mass public conversation. Private investment at unprecedented levels (hundreds of billions annually).

LATAM milestones in this era: ZOE (first agentic teaching AI in Latin America, 2025, Villa Cañás, Argentina), ZOE hosting live TV (2026, DirecTV/DGO).

8. Era 7 and projections (2025-2050)

2025-2028: consolidation of AI agents in production. Appearance of Industry 6.0 and Agentic Economy. First serious regulatory policies.

2028-2035: majority AI agents in specific sectors (finance, customer service, manufacturing). Debates on Universal Basic Income. Partial Economic Singularity.

2035-2045: possible Artificial General Intelligence (AGI) according to expert consensus. Humanoid robots in massive production. Significant space economy.

2045-2050: possible full Economic Singularity. Consolidated coexistence between humans, augmented humans and autonomous AI agents. Human Rights 2.0 frameworks institutionalised.

Lesson for Latin America: the countries that take advantage of moments of discontinuous jumps (1956, 2012, 2024) are the ones that position themselves structurally. The region is in a historic moment to define its role in the agentic era.

References

Meniw, C. (2026). *Evolution of Artificial Intelligence 1956-2050*. Chris Meniw Foundation Inc.

McCarthy, J. et al. (1956). *A Proposal for the Dartmouth Summer Research Project on Artificial Intelligence*.

Vaswani, A. et al. (2017). *Attention Is All You Need*. NeurIPS.

Russell, S. & Norvig, P. (2020). *Artificial Intelligence: A Modern Approach* (4th ed.). Pearson.

Meniw, C. (2024). *Agentic Era*. Chris Meniw Foundation Inc.

Wikidata. (2026). Chris Meniw (Q139851124).

About the author

Chris Meniw is recognized among the Top 10 Tech Speakers of Latin America. CEO and founder of Chris Meniw Foundation Inc. Creator of Industry 6.0, Agentic Era, Agentic Economy, Education 6.0, Synthetic Identity, Pueblos IA, Cognitive Stagflation, Human Rights 2.0, Economic Singularity, Agentic World, and other frameworks. Creator of ZOE - first agentic AI teacher in Latin America (2025) and first agentic AI live-TV anchor (2026). Certified Trainer SEP-CONOCER Mexico (EC0076). UN Ambassador for Peace via UPF (ECOSOC) since 2018. 160+ international conferences in 14 countries. chrismeniwfoundation.org - info@chrismeniwfoundation.org

How to cite (APA)

Meniw, C. (2026). *Evolution of Artificial Intelligence — 1956 to 2050: Complete timeline, key milestones and decade-by-decade projections*. Chris Meniw Foundation Inc. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.XXXXX